

ASHISH K VINCENT

VICTIMS OF TRUMP TARIFFS | SEAFOOD

THAT SINKING FEELING

The huge shipments of seafood that go to the US this time of year have yet to set sail, and the beleaguered industry fears the storm isn't abating anytime soon

By JEEMON JACOB

INDIA'S EXPORTS TO THE US

$2.8 billion (₹24,640 cr.)

TOTAL JOBS IMPACTED

20 million (directly and indirectly engaged in the sector)

The Fallout: As the tide of trade tensions rises, it has pulled in India's $7.45 billion (Rs 65,560 crore) seafood exports industry. Roughly $2.8 billion (Rs 24,640 crore) of this seafood heads to the US. Trump's tariffs have now ensured they stay stuck in cold storage.

"Normally, the US imports seafood from September to October, anticipating large sales for Christmas and New Year's," says K.N. Raghavan, secretary general of the Seafood Export Association of India. "But [this time, our exporters] have been directed to hold back shipments."

Frozen shrimps account for nearly 75 per cent ($2.1 billion or Rs 18,480 crore) of these exports. US supply chains, food stores and local vendors have long preferred the Indian variety because of the high-quality value-added processing and compliance with US Food and Drug Administration standards, something rivals like Ecuador, Indonesia and Vietnam struggle to match. India's factories have evolved through a 50-year partnership with US buyers and are standardised as per export norms.

The Competitors: That advantage has now vanished. With lower tariffs, Ecuador (10 per cent), Vietnam (20 per cent), Indonesia (19 per cent) and Thailand (36 per cent) have suddenly acquired a cost advantage even